



The SR-71 Blackbird, above, and the B2 Stealth Bomber: Like this, but not like this

SKUNK WORKS

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IF IT FLIES and it's secret, then it is a product of the "Skunk Works" — a nickname that has been around for two generations, but not used since the U.S. military withdrew its veil from test flights of the "stealth" aircraft in the 1980s.

The guardians of official secrets, though, have a hard time when it comes to aircraft. They are made to be flown. And people see and hear.

Despite denials from industry sources and bland statements from the Pentagon — "We have no knowledge of such an aircraft" — the evidence stacks up to a near-certainty that a revolutionary step has been made in aircraft design.

Reports date back to summer 1990 of something very unusual taking to the air. Sightings have occurred in many parts of the United States, though they come predominantly from the Mojave Desert region of California.

They nearly always stem from observers schooled in the technology of aviation. For lay witnesses have attributed peculiar sounds and vibrations to earth tremors.

"A strange, loud, pulsating roar" was the way one technical onlooker described it and spoke of the windows rattling. He added that "it was similar to rocket engine noise, but deep with evenly-timed pulses."

This description of the engine sound has characterized witness reports, leading to propulsion experts speculating that that phantom aircraft is driven by a new "impulse motor" — a hybrid of conventional gas turbine and rocket technologies.

Most of the "sightings" are more often simply "hearings", something very fast and very high, and always accompanied by weird-looking vapor trails, displaying the "doughnuts-on-a-rope" pattern known to be associated with a very-high-speed engine.



One witness reporting from Amarillo, Texas, spoke of a clear sky and visibility unlimited, when he heard "a deep-pitched rumble punctuated by short, low-frequency pulses." The aircraft flew out of sight before he could spot it, but he was able to photograph the tell-tale doughnut vapor trail.

Paradoxically, the latest secrecy surrounding the Pulsar Vehicle, a some are calling it, tends to confirm there is something there. In April some radio hobbyists in Southern California were monitoring transmissions between Edwards Air Force Base and a very-high-altitude aircraft using the callsign Gaspise.

Controllers were directing the unknown aircraft to a runway at Edwards AFB. Joshua Control (Edwards) was heard to say to Gaspipe: "You're at 67 (thousand feet). .081 miles out."

When asked by a curious trade press what could be flying at such a height, Pentagon officials replied: "Joshua Control documents contain no record of controllers having worked an aircraft with such a call-sign."

Recent sightings have allowed some close views, resulting in detailed sketches showing similarity one with another. Several observers spoke of a large delta-shaped aircraft with upward-canted vertical fins.

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And then came United Flight 934, a Boeing 747 out of Los Angeles for London on Aug. 5. The captain and co-pilot reported passing through 7,000 metres, when they saw an *unusual aircraft coming directly at them*. There was only a fleeting glimpse — the crew reported a closing rate *two to three times the normal* — as an unidentified object swept beneath them on a near-collision course.

But these two highly-trained observers knew what they saw: a lifting body (type of wingless aircraft) which was clearly supersonic, looking like the forward fuselage of a Lockheed SR-71 Blackbird, the now-grounded CIA spyplane, but without wings.

When asked by the crew what it was, Los Angeles Centre air traffic control replied that they did not see the target on radar. The military liaison officer to the Pacific Region office of the federal aviation administration found nothing to back up the United crew's observation.

An official statement declared: "To us, it's simply a pilot report, and there's no evidence of anything other than the pilot comments." Case closed.

But by now the file was growing: reports of strange objects being seen — mostly bearing a marked similarity — by the trained eyes of independent watchers. The night of July

12 was clear over the Mojave Desert and just before midnight, a motorist sighted an "SR-71-like shape." He stopped the car and there it was, a couple of hundred feet above the road right ahead of him.

Bright moonlight lit the aircraft's shape as it rolled out of a final turn into *Helendale Sun Hill Ranch* airfield — a remote spot, not listed in the National Airport Directory.

With such detailed observations coming in, a consistent picture was emerging: a long delta-shaped platform with a large aft section and slender pointed nose, two rectangular-shaped engine nozzles beneath the aircraft's trailing edge.

Although the concept officially does not exist — no government agency will admit to there being anything behind this growing number of field sightings — there are indications that whatever this highly-classified project is, it is not confined to a research and development undertaking.

Sightings are beginning to occur in Europe. The distinctive high-speed contrail or vapor rings were reported over Scotland emerging from a very-high-flying aircraft.

Speculation, of course. Still, one more witness report claims: "... the front end of a Blackbird-like aircraft being loaded into a C-5 freighter at Burbank, California." Home to Lockheed's Skunk Works. □